Team 74, Sprint 3, Week 3, Task 90

Branding and Participants Tab in the OAPA Isolated Environment

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Project	Building an Editor Academy Moodle platform (Team A)
Client contact	Michael, OAPA Academy
Date	27 October 2026
Status	Started but not finished. OAPA is happy with the local Moodle handover. I'm carrying on next week in OAPA's private environment.

Summary

For this task I tried to move the OAPA branding and the new Participants tab from our local Moodle into the isolated environment OAPA Academy gave us. Both already work in our local Moodle (Tasks 69, 79 and 80) and the code is in the Local-Moodle repo, in the `oapa-branding` folder (commit d389731fe).

I didn't manage to finish it. I ran into five problems, and two of them were big ones. The isolated site isn't on the Boost theme, which is what all our styling was written for, and the scripts I put in Additional HTML didn't run there. The Participants page and the course tabs both rely on those scripts. On top of that, saving the Raw SCSS caused errors, the brand fonts were blocked, and the caches made it hard to tell if a change had worked at all.

I talked to Michael from OAPA Academy about where things were. He was happy to get the local Moodle as the handover and said finishing it in the isolated environment wasn't something we had to do. I offered to keep working on the branding in their private environment next week, and he said I didn't have to, but they'd appreciate it.

1. What I was moving

Everything here uses Moodle's own settings, so there's no core code or plugin to install. On our local site one script, `apply.php`, sets it all and clears the caches. On the isolated site I started putting the same SCSS and Additional HTML into the same settings by hand. This is what goes where:

Part	Moodle setting	File
Black and white colours, layout, header, left panel, buttons, dark mode	Appearance > Themes > Boost: Raw initial SCSS and Raw SCSS	oapa-pre.scss (27 lines), oapa.scss (1,502 lines)
Newsreader and Archivo fonts	Appearance > Additional HTML: Within HEAD	head.html
Participants page, Quizzes and Assignments tabs, left panel closed on non-course tabs	Appearance > Additional HTML: Before BODY is closed	footer.html (326 lines, two scripts)
Header and login logo	Appearance > Logos, Boost login background image	oapa-logo-tight.png, oapa-login-panel.png

2. What went wrong

The site isn't on Boost

Once the SCSS was in, only some pages changed. The rest kept the site's own look. Our SCSS was built and tested on Boost, Moodle's default theme (the hosted Academy we checked on 10 Oct was on Boost too, so that's what we built for). The Raw initial SCSS sets Boost variables like `$primary`, `$navbar-height` and `$drawer-left-width`, and most of oapa.scss is aimed at Boost's layout: the header, the course drawer, the tab row and the main content area. A different theme has its own variables and its own page structure, so a lot of these rules just don't match anything.

So this isn't something I could fix in a few minutes. The SCSS has to be gone through against that theme, page by page, and then every page we covered locally has to be tested again.

Settings saved, but nothing changed

The settings saved fine, but the site looked exactly the same afterwards. Moodle builds the theme CSS once and caches it, and it caches parts of pages too, so changes only show after a cache purge (Site administration > Development > Purge all caches) and a hard reload. I never noticed this locally because apply.php purges the caches by itself.

On its own that's easy to deal with. The problem was that together with the theme issue, I often couldn't tell if a change had failed or just wasn't showing yet, and that slowed the testing down a lot.

SCSS errors when saving

Saving the Raw SCSS either gave an error, or it saved and the whole site lost its styling. Moodle compiles our SCSS together with the theme's own SCSS into one stylesheet. Our code expects things that Boost provides, and if the theme doesn't have them the compile fails. When that happens Moodle has no stylesheet to send, so every page shows up unstyled.

This is the main reason I couldn't just keep trying things. It's OAPA's environment, and one bad save takes the styling off every page for anyone using it. It can be undone by clearing the Raw SCSS and purging the caches, but every attempt still carries that risk. To fix it properly the SCSS needs rewriting for that theme, and ideally testing on a copy of the theme first.

Brand fonts blocked

Newsreader and Archivo didn't load, so the pages fell back to a default font. head.html loads both fonts from Google Fonts, and the isolated environment blocks those outside requests. The Brand Book only allows these two fonts, so I couldn't check the typography against it. The fix is to upload the font files to the site and load them from there instead. That needs file access on the site and a few SCSS changes, so I've put it on next week's list.

Scripts not running

The colours changed, but the Participants page and the course tabs stayed as plain Moodle. CSS can't rebuild the Participants page or change which tabs Moodle shows, so locally I do this with two scripts in footer.html, saved in Additional HTML. The first one rebuilds the Participants page to match Walaa's mock-ups, on top of Moodle's own table, search and download. Students see Name and Role only, and teachers get tick boxes, Group, Last access and Download report. The second one swaps the Activities tab for Quizzes and Assignments and closes the left panel on non-course tabs. In the isolated environment the scripts were blocked or stripped out, so none of that happened.

That's basically the whole Participants tab part of the task, and I can't work around it with CSS. Either OAPA's admin lets the scripts run on their site, or the same changes get moved into a theme or a small plugin. Both of those are OAPA's call for their own environment, so I didn't want to change it myself.

3. Why it's not finished

These problems are tied together. The theme difference is what causes the SCSS errors, and it means the styling has to be reworked rather than just copied across. The blocked scripts stop the Participants page and the tabs completely, and fixing that depends on OAPA's settings. The caches and fonts were smaller things, but they made every test slower and harder to read.

Finishing it would have meant rewriting a big part of the SCSS for a theme it wasn't made for and changing security settings on OAPA's site, all without leaving the site broken for anyone else. I couldn't do that safely in the time left before handover.

There's also one limit we already knew about from Task 80 (D10). The H5P Check button stays blue because H5P runs in its own frame. That needs H5P custom styles from the OAPA admin, or the native quiz fallback, on any site.

4. Talking to Michael

I spoke with Michael from OAPA Academy about where the work was at. He said he was satisfied with getting the local Moodle as the handover, and that finishing the implementation in the isolated environment wasn't an obligation for us.

I offered to keep working on the branding in OAPA Academy's private environment the following week. Michael said I wasn't required to, but they would appreciate it if I did.

This lines up with what Michael said at the 27 October closeout meeting (Aryan's Task 81 record): the local release is the handover, and moving it onto OAPA's server is a follow-up if it's doable.

5. Next week

1. Find out which theme the private environment uses and adjust the SCSS for it, starting with the header, tab row, left panel and buttons.
2. Save the SCSS in small pieces and purge the caches after each save, so if something breaks I know straight away which part did it and can undo it.
3. Upload Newsreader and Archivo to the site and load them from there instead of Google Fonts.
4. Ask OAPA's admin if the Additional HTML scripts can be allowed. If not, write up what a theme or plugin version of the Participants page and tabs would need.
5. Check the login page, course page, Participants (as a student and a teacher), the tabs, light and dark mode and a phone screen, then send Michael and the team a short update.

6. Where things stand

- Handed over: the local Moodle with the full branding and Participants tab, and the `oapa-branding` code in Local-Moodle (commit d389731fe). Michael accepted this.
- Not finished: the same work in the isolated environment, for the reasons above. Michael confirmed this wasn't required.
- Next: I keep working on the branding in OAPA's private environment next week, like I offered.
- If anything needs undoing on that site: clear Raw initial SCSS, Raw SCSS and both Additional HTML fields, then purge all caches.